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Equity Research
7 July 2026

U.S. Digital Advertising

Consumer AI Starting to Take Shape - 2Q Preview

We like GOOGL, META and PINS into the print. We expect a solid quarter from the digital advertising group in 2Q, with key revenue growth rates broadly in line to above the Street. Trends should slow through '26 but already factored into consensus expectations.

The Key Takeaway: Stock prices across the digital advertising sector have been reacting more to AI trends and winner/loser baskets of late, rather than core financial results. GOOGL is benefiting mostly from GCP growth (and in 2Q likely the TPUaaS business) rather than Search revenue growth rates. META remains in the sentiment doghouse, and we think the company could surprise on AI in 2H (both models and products) while ad revenue growth should remain steady. PINS is likely to get things back on track in 2Q (see below) and arguably has the best setup in the group heading into late '26 as core ads start to outperform. SNAP has been volatile around the Specs launch, but its ad business seems to be improving a bit in 2Q. This is all playing out as consumer AI seems on the verge of its next major push since ChatGPT's original debut. Native AI advertising remains nascent and isn't likely to have an impact on the group in 2Q. In summary, the backdrop remains broadly constructive for digital advertising: 1) fears around AI disruption risk seem a bit overblown, and 2) most names are currently trading at a discount to the S&P 500.

Most Ad Categories Tracking Solidly in 2Q: Retail represents upwards of 20-25% of ad spend for larger walled gardens, and up to 85%+ for companies like Pinterest. With the combination of late-quarter promotions falling in 2Q this year (Prime Day, etc.) and some tariff refunds coming through to various brands and retailers being redeployed into customer acquisition, we think trends were broadly stable. Travel seemed to have picked up a bit as Middle East tensions eased and one-off events like World Cup helped demand. AI-native apps are being created and launched at a rapid pace, and often come with heavy direct response ad buys to increase awareness. Lastly, prediction market apps have hit product market fit in 2026 and seem to be leaning into digital marketing, which could result in billions of ad dollars for the largest ecosystems.

Consumer AI on the Verge of Its Agentic Moment - Siri AI Could Restart the Consumer Race

The Siri AI debut at WWDC looked impressive from the standpoint of being the first "safe and normie" consumer AI app that defaults connectors across Apple's suite of O+O applications into

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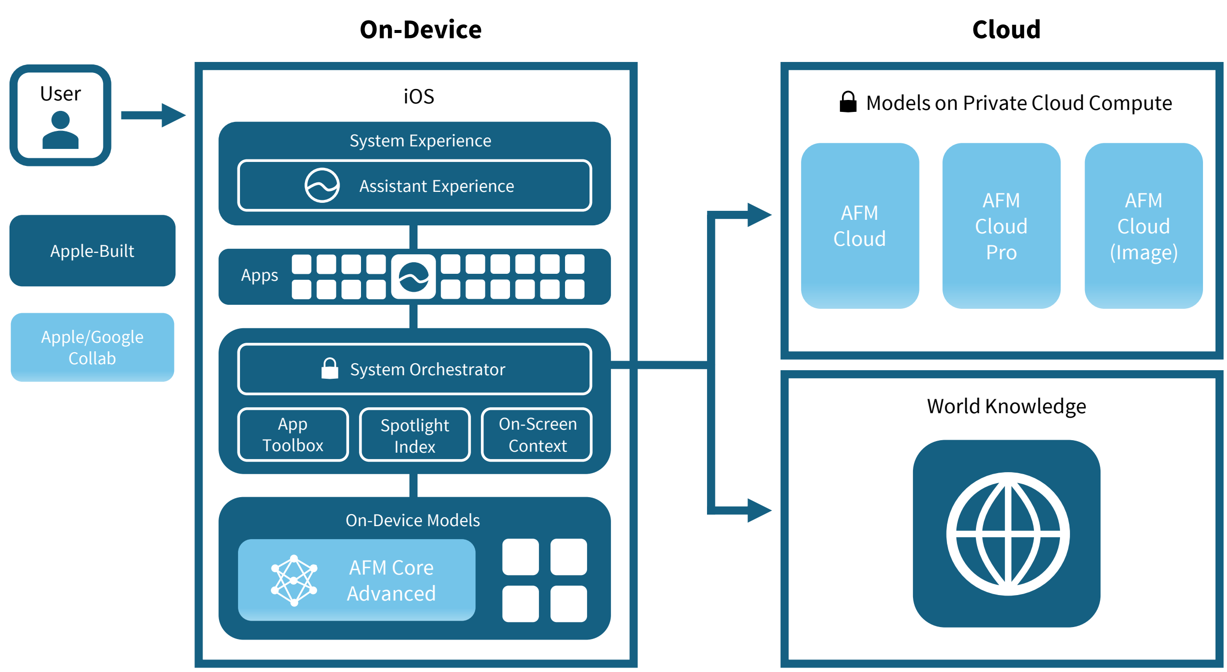
the service for personalization. Gemini and ChatGPT have developer SDKs and plug-ins, but on a consumer opt-in basis they aren't in the same trusted position as Apple, nor do they sit at the OS/device levels. This kind of personalized service with connectors is likely to be what will push the consumer AI space into its next stage, much like how ChatGPT's original debut triggered chatbot adoption. Often a precursor to the West, we are seeing this trend already happening in China – WeChat is integrating its 4m mini-programs into its AI service, allowing consumers to take action, not just chat.

Apple went further out of its way to show off how the orchestration and routing layers of their new AI stack are largely built in-house (in some cases distilled from Gemini) and are not sending queries to other AI models, outside of a few complex tasks. This release was impressive in our view from the standpoint of abstracting away some of the complicated set-up steps for personalized consumer AI, allowing the user to take action, not just chat, and giving Apple much more control of the user interaction layer on the iPhone.

FIGURE 1. Apple Looks to Control Much More of the AI Experience (and the User Interaction Layer) with Siri AI



Source: Barclays Research, Company Disclosures

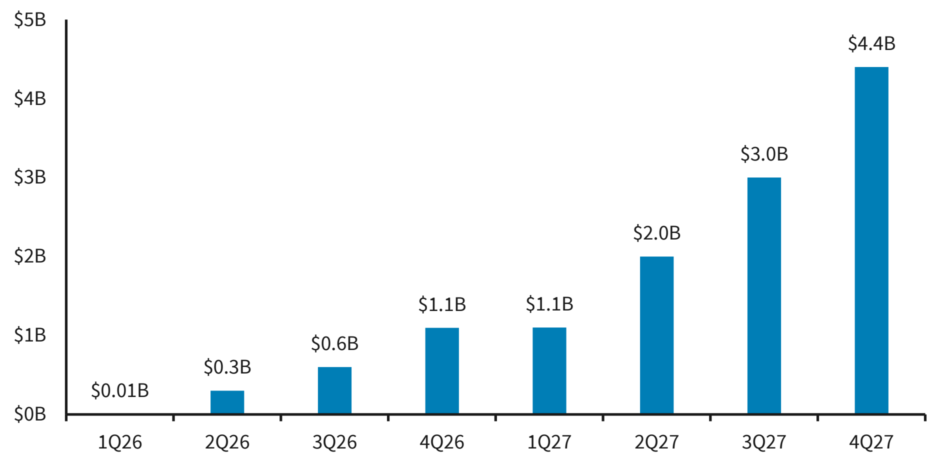
Like WeChat, Apple is attempting to control most of the transactions between the user and third-party applications like DoorDash and Instacart via the App Intent API. In 2Q, ByteDance introduced paid tiers to its popular consumer AI service Doubao ranging from $10-$70 per month, comparable to ChatGPT (~5% payers), so we are likely to see other examples of consumer agent business models take form. All of this is to say that if Siri AI gains traction after being rolled out this fall, we believe it could direct some transactions away from existing channels and into Apple-controlled services.

Noted above, other consumer AI services are building the same capabilities, including Google's Gemini, Meta AI and ChatGPT via various third-party app integrations. To the degree that this kind of interaction between consumer agentic AI services and third-party apps takes off, it could shift ad dollars out of Search and Social, or could potentially be deflationary to overall digital advertising (but still TBD, depending on adoption).

ChatGPT Ads Still Tiny, But Growing Fast

Somewhat related to consumer agentic AI adoption, we are monitoring how native AI advertising within these new surfaces is progressing. We aren't yet concerned around chatbot ads taking share from the legacy digital channels. There appears to be some anecdotal examples of companies/agencies cutting back on digital to fund chatbot ads, but in our view this is unlikely to be an issue in 2Q. We estimate AI ads could hit a $1B quarterly run rate by 4Q26, at which point the industry may have to start taking notice. Until then, trends and market share in core digital should remain largely as is.

FIGURE 2. **ChatGPT Ads Could Reach $1B Per Quarter By 4Q26**



Source: Barclays Research, The Information, Company Disclosures

Company-Specific 2Q Previews

GOOGL: Checks remain solid in 2Q, and we are expecting similar growth in 2Q (ex-fx) for Google's ad businesses. We estimate Search revenue growth of 16% Y/Y (15% ex-fx) in 2Q, which seems appropriate based on the set-up. Query growth has picked up from AI Overviews and AI Mode adoption, including the higher "refresh" rate on some of these queries. The reduction in organic traffic referrals continues to force brands to allocate more to paid search in order to grow. At the same time the company is starting to experiment with native AI ads in some of these new surfaces. We expect queries to remain elevated and paid click-through rates (CTR) to pick up potentially over the next year, but not likely by enough to drive above-industry growth in Search revenue. We expect YouTube +10% Y/Y in 2Q with some small help from the World Cup campaigns on the brand side, but ad growth continues to lag on the mix shift towards ad-free subscriptions. GCP should once again be the standout based on a combination of factors: Anthropic (private) and the overall inference side of GCP inflecting higher. We expect Google Cloud to grow well north of last quarter's 63% Y/Y as agentic enterprise AI appears to have really hit its stride in 2Q. EPS likely benefits once again from below-the-line gains in non-marketable securities from recent IPOs.

META: Advances in META's ad stack continue to drive subtle but important improvements in revenue trajectory. Engagement per user is up across IG and Blue based on content recommendations. Ad load is also going up dynamically, while ad targeting continues to improve. The company introduced its Adaptive Ranking Model in 4Q25 and has rolled it out more broadly since, and we think 2Q trends may have benefited to some degree. Some of the historical model tweaks have been subtle in terms of revenue impact, but this one seems more significant and could be more meaningful over time. We are modeling $59B in ad revenue (+25% ex-fx) which could prove conservative by a point or two. We aren't expecting any major surprises on the Capex or Opex outlooks in 2Q. We doubt the debate around equity financing needs or cloud tokens-as-a-service will be fully put to bed until the next Muse models are released, but we would use the recent volatility to add to positions.

PINS: As noted above, our checks suggest retail had a solid 2Q with late-quarter promotions helping a bit. We hosted an NDR for PINS management in early June and the tone was broadly upbeat. Direct response may see some improvement from tariff relief, and the company expressed excitement about what they expect TVScientific will bring to the table. Search ads for 3P-CTV is a nascent opportunity that only Amazon, and now PINS, are really pursuing at this point. Small advertiser spend should continue to outpace the larger accounts on PINS, on the back of Performance+. We expect some headwinds to Europe from the sales reorg, but that's well documented and we believe is already reflected in consensus. 2Q and the outlook for 2H could see slight upside for PINS vs our estimates; we are modeling revenue of $1.15b (+15% Y/Y).

SNAP: We are hopeful that SNAP could get things back on track in 2Q. The company is lapping some company-specific snafus in direct response, in addition to the tariff-related cuts last year, both of which should see solid improvement. We expect core ad growth to pick up from 3% in 1Q to somewhere in the mid-single-digits in 2Q. Sponsored Snaps remains the new product most in favor for Snapchat, with increased focus on brands leveraging smaller groups and private conversations vs. the traditional social media ad buys. SNAP's brand advertising has been declining for a few quarters, so we would view any new signs of life as a positive. The Specs launch was met with new investor skepticism, but we note that the company packed a lot of technology into the form factor (comparable to a META Orion prototype) and can always slim things down in consumer v2 (which could already be in development). The company does have a nice lead in AR technology and the ecosystem around lens studio which it can leverage. The activist campaign seems to have come and gone without much impact, which may explain some of the weakness in shares since the Specs launch. Specs de-consolidation remains an option for Snap.

LFTO: We just initiated coverage of Liftoff, so for more detail on our thesis refer to Performance Rules Everything Around Me, 6/29/26. 2Q should have upside to the 28% Y/Y growth forecasted by consensus as the company continues to benefit from internal model updates that drive share gains within gaming and rapid growth in new categories like retail and prediction markets. 1Q had a successful model update, hence the company stated it doesn't expect the same level of growth in 2Q (FX was also a smaller tailwind).

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Materially Mentioned Stocks (Ticker, Date, Price)
Alphabet Inc. (GOOGL, 02-Jul-2026, USD 359.91), Overweight/Positive, A/CD/CE/D/E/J/K/L/M/N

Liftoff Mobile, Inc. (LFTO, 02-Jul-2026, USD 24.46), Overweight/Positive, A/CE/D/E/J/L

Meta Platforms, Inc. (META, 02-Jul-2026, USD 582.90), Overweight/Positive, CD/CE/J/K/M/N

Pinterest, Inc. (PINS, 02-Jul-2026, USD 22.07), Equal Weight/Positive, CE/D/J/L

Snap, Inc (SNAP, 02-Jul-2026, USD 4.84), Overweight/Positive, CD/CE/J/K/N

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Etsy Inc (ETSY)	Expedia Inc. (EXPE)	Liftoff Mobile, Inc. (LFTO)
Lyft, Inc. (LYFT)	Maplebear, Inc. (CART)	Match Group, Inc. (MTCH)
Meta Platforms, Inc. (META)	Pinterest, Inc. (PINS)	Roblox Corporation (RBLX)
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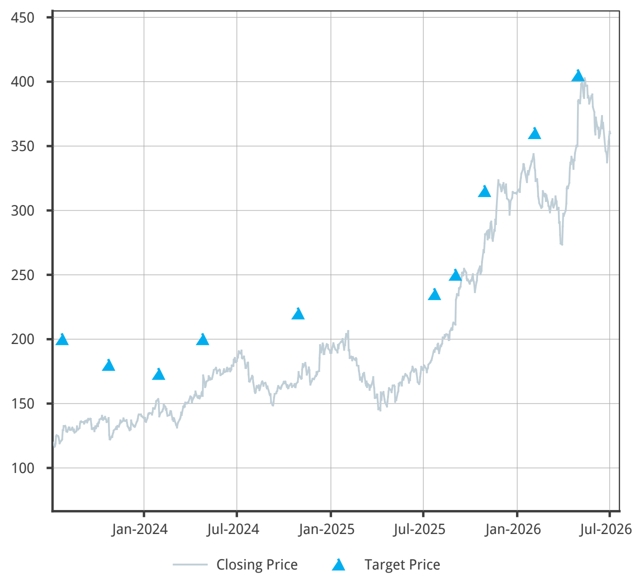
Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 359.91** (02-Jul-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 02-Jul-2026)



Source: IDC, Barclays Research

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Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target	Currency
30-Apr-2026	349.94		405.00	USD
04-Feb-2026	333.04		360.00	USD
29-Oct-2025	274.57		315.00	USD
02-Sep-2025	212.91		250.00	USD
23-Jul-2025	190.23		235.00	USD
29-Oct-2024	169.68		220.00	USD
25-Apr-2024	156.00		200.00	USD
30-Jan-2024	151.46		173.00	USD
24-Oct-2023	138.81		180.00	USD
25-Jul-2023	122.21		200.00	USD

On 06-Jul-2023, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Overweight, and the adjusted price target was 160.00 USD.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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Valuation Methodology: Our $405 price target is based on an average of 25x EPS and 15x EBITDA multiples on our blended FY27E/FY28E estimates.

Risks which May Impede the Achievement of the Barclays Research Valuation and Price Target: Increasing competition and regulatory issues could cause multiple compression and downward estimate revisions, while continued innovation, successful product launches and an uptick in GCP adoption could cause upside to our current estimates.

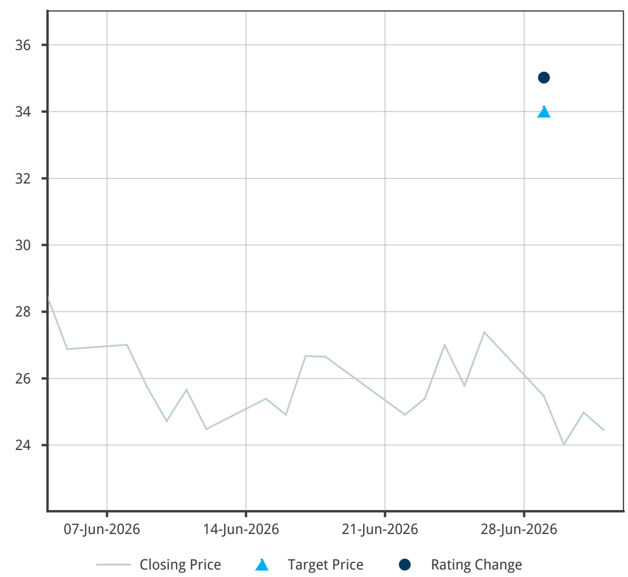
Liftoff Mobile, Inc. (LFTO / LFTO)

Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 24.46** (02-Jul-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 02-Jul-2026)



Source: IDC, Barclays Research

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Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target	Currency
29-Jun-2026	27.39	Overweight	34.00	USD

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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Valuation Methodology: Our PT of $34 is based on a blended average of 15x Adj. EBITDA, a 4% FCF yield, and 25x GAAP EPS on our 2027 estimates.

Risks which May Impede the Achievement of the Barclays Research Valuation and Price Target: Digital advertising is a hyper-competitive space with very little revenue lock in or visibility. Public ad tech companies have a mixed history in terms of stock performance. Liftoff's growth formula is predicated on continued secular industry growth and share gains from AI based model improvements to Cortex, neither of which are guaranteed to continue. Large players like GOOGL and META may decide to re-join the ad tech space in a more meaningful way, which could pull ad dollars away from companies like Liftoff.

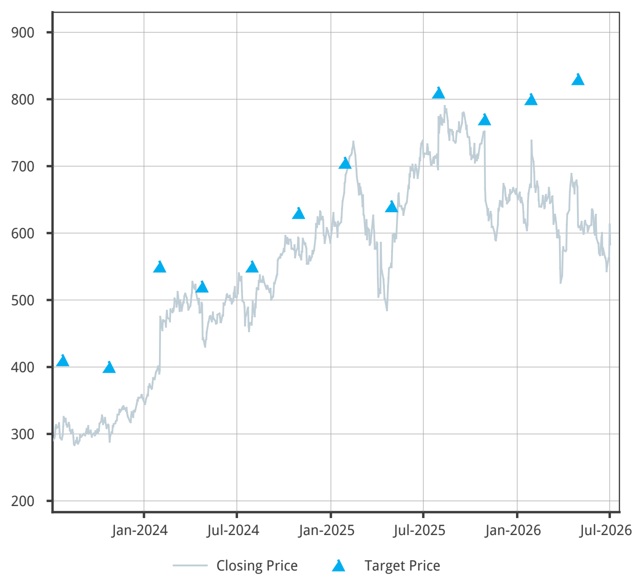
Meta Platforms, Inc. (META / META)

Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 582.90** (02-Jul-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 02-Jul-2026)



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Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target	Currency
30-Apr-2026	669.12		830.00	USD
28-Jan-2026	668.73		800.00	USD
29-Oct-2025	751.67		770.00	USD
31-Jul-2025	695.21		810.00	USD
30-Apr-2025	549.00		640.00	USD
29-Jan-2025	676.49		705.00	USD
30-Oct-2024	591.80		630.00	USD
31-Jul-2024	474.83		550.00	USD
24-Apr-2024	493.50		520.00	USD
01-Feb-2024	394.78		550.00	USD
25-Oct-2023	299.53		400.00	USD
26-Jul-2023	298.57		410.00	USD

On 06-Jul-2023, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Overweight, and the adjusted price target was 320.00 USD.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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Valuation Methodology: Our $830 price target is based on an average of 25x EPS and 12x EBITDA on our FY27E estimates.

Risks which May Impede the Achievement of the Barclays Research Valuation and Price Target: We believe upside risk exists from FB's innovative products which could drive higher than expected engagement, investor concerns around ad load which could prove to be overblown, and incremental revenue from FB Messenger and WhatsApp. Downside risk could arise from a slowdown in US/Europe, cannibalization of ad revenue from video, and increasing competition.

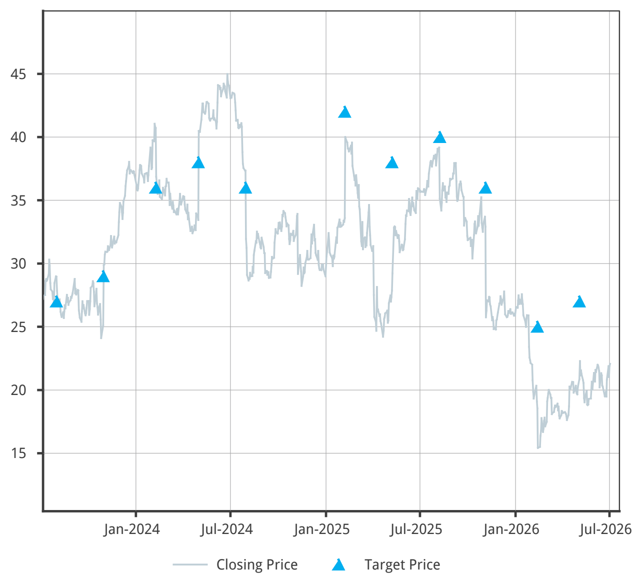
Pinterest, Inc. (PINS / PINS)

Stock Rating: **EQUAL WEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 22.07** (02-Jul-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 02-Jul-2026)



Source: IDC, Barclays Research

Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target	Currency
04-May-2026	20.85		27.00	USD
12-Feb-2026	18.54		25.00	USD
04-Nov-2025	32.91		36.00	USD
08-Aug-2025	39.17		40.00	USD
08-May-2025	27.86		38.00	USD
06-Feb-2025	33.59		42.00	USD
30-Jul-2024	37.35		36.00	USD
30-Apr-2024	33.45		38.00	USD
08-Feb-2024	40.72		36.00	USD
30-Oct-2023	25.10		29.00	USD
01-Aug-2023	28.96		27.00	USD

On 06-Jul-2023, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Equal Weight, and the adjusted price target was 26.00 USD.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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Valuation Methodology: Our $27 PT is based on 10x EBITDA on our FY27 estimates.

Risks which May Impede the Achievement of the Barclays Research Valuation and Price Target: 1) its current stretched valuation vs. peers (which we see often for new mobile ads IPOs) 2) competition with Instagram for users and advertisers 3) niche audience compared to larger platforms 4) the future growth potential from non-endemic advertising categories outside of retail and CPG, and 5) some dependency on others for user growth (the 2Q18 hiccup issue).

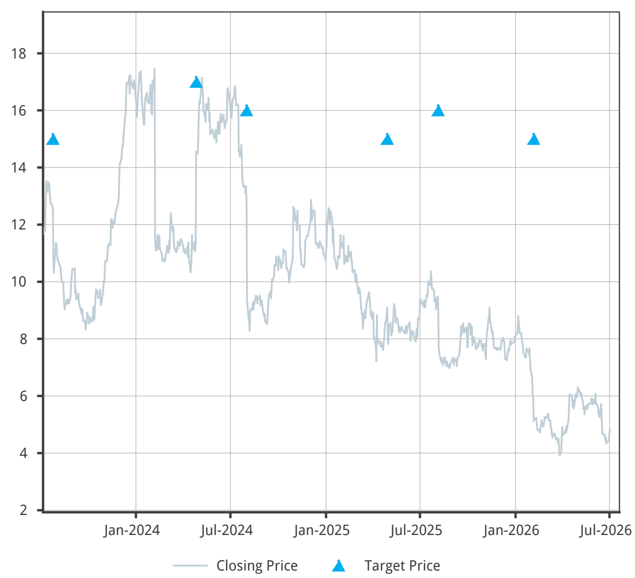
Snap, Inc (SNAP / SNAP)

Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 4.84** (02-Jul-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 02-Jul-2026)



Source: IDC, Barclays Research

Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target	Currency
05-Feb-2026	5.91		15.00	USD
05-Aug-2025	9.39		16.00	USD
29-Apr-2025	9.09		15.00	USD
01-Aug-2024	12.81		16.00	USD
26-Apr-2024	11.40		17.00	USD
25-Jul-2023	12.51		15.00	USD

On 06-Jul-2023, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Overweight, and the adjusted price target was 11.00 USD.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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Valuation Methodology: Our price target of $15 is based on a 5x EV/Revenue and 15x EV/EBITDA multiple on our 2027 estimates.

Risks which May Impede the Achievement of the Barclays Research Valuation and Price Target: Risks include: 1) a slowdown in user growth and engagement decline, 2) lack of profitability, 3) risks around advertising ROI, 4) multiple compression due to sentiment change, and 5) competition from Instagram and other social networks.

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